

Deep Utopia: Life and Meaning in a Solved World

Nick Bostrom

Nick Bostrom's *Deep Utopia: Life and Meaning in a Solved World* explores the trajectory of human civilization toward a future where abundance, automation, and technological maturity reshape society's purpose. He begins by emphasizing the importance of cultivating wisdom and cooperative behavior, arguing that these qualities are essential for securing a sustainable and meaningful future. Material progress, while a relatively modern invention, has driven exponential growth in population and GDP over millennia, yet it also highlights the rise of positional goods—scarce resources or status symbols that drive wasteful competition. This critique of contemporary consumption underscores the need to refocus societal goals toward cultural and ethical enrichment rather than relentless economic expansion.

Bostrom revisits the concept of automation, exploring how mistrust of AI may give way to a reliance on machine intelligence for decision-making and task execution. This shift could free humanity from mundane labor but raises questions about purpose in a world without work. Historical perspectives, such as Keynes' concerns about abundance leading to existential malaise, underscore the difficulty of transitioning from striving for survival to enjoying leisure and fulfillment. Bostrom proposes a cultural overhaul of education and values, suggesting that future generations be trained not for productivity but for flourishing and the art of enjoying life.

The author examines the "purpose problem," a phenomenon amplified in post-scarcity societies where traditional roles and goals lose relevance. While some argue leisure culture can fill the void left by work, Bostrom cautions that even leisure activities may eventually seem pointless. The loss of meaning, he suggests, stems from the disappearance of challenges that make life interesting. Drawing on Schopenhauer and others, he highlights aesthetic contemplation and the appreciation of beauty as possible antidotes to ennui, suggesting that fulfillment might lie in finding joy in the mundane rather than seeking extraordinary achievements.

Bostrom also discusses the implications of technological "plasticity," the ability to modify oneself physically and mentally to achieve any desired state. While this offers unprecedented freedom, it introduces risks of meaninglessness if life becomes unmoored from challenges and limitations. The interplay between utopia and dystopia emerges here: post-scarcity conditions might reduce suffering but could also lead to alienation and a lack of purpose. The dilemma reflects Schopenhauer's view of life as oscillating between pain and boredom, with technological maturity potentially eliminating both but at the cost of depth and meaning.

A recurring theme in **Deep Utopia** is the human need for meaning, often derived from striving toward goals or embodying roles. Bostrom argues that meaning is rooted in pursuits that transcend mundane existence, connecting individuals to broader values, ideals, or collective endeavors. For example, acts of devotion to art, science, or moral causes can provide fulfillment even in a world devoid of material hardship. However, the proliferation of alternative lifestyles and ideologies in liberal societies can make it harder for individuals to choose or commit to a singular purpose, exacerbating the crisis of meaning.

In discussing meaning-based motivation, Bostrom suggests that it arises from convictions rather than immediate rewards. This aligns with Nietzsche's assertion that understanding one's "why" makes enduring any "how" possible. Yet, he warns that the erosion of traditional constraints and the rise of secular, multicultural societies could dilute the clarity of meaningful missions. The paradox of abundance, then, is that while it frees us from survival pressures, it challenges us to find new, compelling reasons to act, create, and connect.

Bostrom explores the role of culture in shaping meaning, noting how social esteem incentivizes projects that might otherwise seem arbitrary. Activities like sports or artistic endeavors acquire significance through cultural endorsement, transforming personal pursuits into sources of collective value. Similarly, personal relationships provide a sense of

irreplaceability, offering individuals an anchor for meaning. Even as technology threatens to quantify and technologize human connections, the persistence of intuitive and affective bonds offers hope for retaining some sense of enchantment in life.

The book also delves into philosophical frameworks for meaning, drawing from thinkers like Albert Camus and Arthur Schopenhauer. Bostrom contrasts subjective meaning—derived from individual purpose—with objective meaning, which relies on broader moral or existential justifications. He suggests that the most enduring sources of meaning might involve a synthesis of personal fulfillment and contributions to collective or transcendent ideals. This pluralistic approach acknowledges the complexity of human aspirations, resisting the urge to reduce meaning to a single metric or criterion.

Ultimately, Bostrom envisions a utopia where technological advancements provide unprecedented opportunities for richness, fulfillment, and psychological growth. However, he remains cautious about the challenges of sustaining purpose and avoiding existential crises in such a world. The pursuit of a meaningful life, he concludes, may require continuous engagement with fundamental questions of value, beauty, and morality. By fostering a culture that prioritizes these higher aspirations, humanity can navigate the profound transformations ahead while preserving its capacity for joy, connection, and meaning.

Excerpts

Location: 657

think you can make a case that wisdom and wide-scoped cooperativeness are the two qualities currently most needful to secure a great future for our Earth-sprouted civilization. I also think wealth, stability, security, and peace are better for wisdom and global cooperation than are their opposites. And so we should welcome advancements in these directions, not only because they are good for us now, but also because they are good for humanity's future.

Location: 694

One is reminded of the famous lines uttered by Harry Lime in *The Third Man*: “You know what the fellow said—in Italy, for thirty years under the Borgias, they had warfare, terror, murder and bloodshed, but they produced Michelangelo, Leonardo da Vinci and the Renaissance. In Switzerland, they had brotherly love, they had five hundred years of democracy and peace—and what did that produce? The cuckoo clock.”

Location: 852

So the idea of material progress is a surprisingly modern invention. Nevertheless, looking back, we can now see that a lot of technological advancement did take place over the ages, leading to a 200-fold increase in world GDP and world population—the two being essentially equivalent in the Malthusian condition—over the last 10,000 years until the onset of the Industrial Revolution; and then a further 100-fold increase in world GDP along with an 10-fold increase in world population—and thus a 10-fold increase in average income—from the outset of the Industrial Revolution to the present age. The doubling time for the world economy was around tens of thousands of years for hunter-gatherers; around a thousand for agriculturalists; and around thirty years for industrial-era humanity.

Location: 1,475

the concept of positional goods is important not only in analyzing future utopias but also for understanding the underpinning of our contemporary societies, as expounded on by, for instance, Fred Hirsch in his 1977 book, *Social Limits to Growth*.⁶⁵ The richer we become, the more of our desires for non-positional goods, such as basic food and shelter, are met; and the greater the fraction of our remaining as-yet unfulfilled desires pertain to positional goods, which are inherently scarce. Thus we are spending an increasing fraction of our time and income jockeying for position—anything from prestigious job titles to exclusive fashion accessories. But a side effect of one person's outlays on such goods is that they raise the bar for everybody else. The harder one person competes to make it into the elite, and the more time and money he devotes to out-strutting his rivals, the greater the costs that anyone else must bear if they wish to have a shot at being alpha. The result is a vast amount of socially

wasteful expenditure. The fraction of GDP that is devoted to such mostly zero-sum status consumption increases as the economy grows, limiting the extent to which economic growth translates into improvements in welfare.

Location: 1,751

The human identity might be ascertainable only via expert certification, but it could still be an important determinant of value, just as an authentic artwork by a master is worth a lot more than a nearly indistinguishable replica—perhaps because it is more prestigious to own the original than the copy. Since only human beings can produce “goods and services produced by human beings”, humans could remain economically competitive in sectors of the economy where such status considerations are important.

Location: 1,790

In principle, mistrust could limit the uptake of automation no matter how capable and efficient machines become. It seems plausible, however, that trust barriers will eventually erode, as artificial systems accumulate track records that rival or exceed those of human decision-makers, or as we discover other ways to verify reliability and alignment. In time, machines will probably become more trusted than humans.

Location: 1,802

We may come to rely on AI recommendations and evaluations, which we may find to be more consistent and predictive than our own snap judgments about which decisions would be in our best long-term interest (or about what we ourselves would have decided if we had put in the time and effort to carefully reflect on the options in light of all the relevant facts). Even the onus of making decisions about what we want may thus ultimately be lifted from our shoulders.

Location: 2,045

Keynes worried about what would happen once the strenuous efforts of the moneymakers carry all of us along “into the lap of economic abundance”: “There is no country and no people, I think, who can look forward to the age of leisure and of abundance without a dread. For we have been trained too long to strive and not to enjoy. It is a fearful problem for the ordinary person, with no special talents, to occupy himself, especially if he no longer has roots in the soil or in custom or in the beloved conventions of a traditional society. To judge from the behaviour and the achievements of the wealthy classes today in any quarter of the world, the outlook is very depressing! For these are, so to speak, our advance guard—those who are spying out the promised land for the rest of us and pitching their camp there.”⁷⁷

Location: 2,234

In any case, if we imagine a world in which the need for work was removed, then clearly there would be an opportunity and a need for the focus of education to change. Instead of shaping children to become productive workers, we should try to educate them to become flourishing human beings. People with a high level of skill in the art of enjoying life.

Location: 2,260

Would we get bored if we lived in a world without work? “Millions long for immortality who don’t know what to do with themselves on a rainy Sunday afternoon.”⁹⁶ On the face of it, the problem we confront here is not that theoretically complicated. There are many worthwhile things that humans do in life that are not geared toward making money. If we get more leisure, we can do more of those things.

Location: 2,399

Today’s societies may set themselves goals such as clean air, good schools, high-quality healthcare, adequate pensions, an efficient transportation system, and so forth. Once those goals have been achieved, ambition could turn in more cultural directions: let’s say, to create a society where people care about one another, where individual differences are recognized and celebrated, where many people come together to create large happenings, where customs are continuously refined to make daily interactions more meaningful and fulfilling, and where there are constantly renewed efforts to deepen and broaden the public discourse about art, religion, ethics, literature, media, technology, politics, science, history, and philosophy. And

so on and so forth. Again, a significant transition—but, really, an opportunity rather than a problem.

Location: 2,429

Machine superintelligence, and other innovations that will accompany this advance, can do so much more than substitute for you in the workplace; they will also remove the need for many other kinds of human striving. This means that the mycelium of “the purpose problem” extends far wider and deeper than the parts that are familiar in forms such as how to occupy oneself during an extended holiday or when one is too young, too old, or too rich to work.

Location: 2,475

The upshot is that the activity of shopping would be radically transformed. The activity could disappear altogether—the AI doing it all, without your involvement. Alternatively, shopping could metamorphose into an activity that is more akin to watching a videofeed about merchandise and people’s opinions about it. The video could be highly immersive, customized to your interests, and focused on you, your friends, and your favorite celebrities, and it would inform you about what they think of you and the options available to you (or, in the case of celebrities, what they would think about these things if they knew you).

Location: 2,625

Only a small fraction of parenting consists of “precious moments”—imparting some pearl of life wisdom, being delighted by some expression of the child’s naive creativity, receiving a spontaneous hug or other sign of affection or gratitude. Even if the frequency of these moments could be doubled or tripled, they do not seem to be the kind of thing that, on their own, could fill our days with purposeful activity.

Location: 2,644

The idea of a robot that is a perfect parent-substitute might sound far-fetched. We will not discuss the mechanics of implementation here; but I think that at technological maturity this would in fact be possible. A superintelligent AI could build such a thing for us.

Location: 2,710

The traditional and relatively superficial version of the purpose problem—let’s call it shallow redundancy—is that human occupational labor may become obsolete due to progress in automation, which, with the right economic policies, would inaugurate an age of abundance. This would be a condition of great general prosperity and material plenty. Since it would eliminate both the need and the opportunity for paid work, it would cause one source of purpose to dry up, namely the purpose that many people currently find in their jobs.

Location: 2,715

The solution to shallow redundancy is to develop a leisure culture. Leisure culture would raise and educate people to thrive in unemployment.

Location: 2,728

The more fundamental version of the purpose problem that is now coming into view—let’s call it deep redundancy—is that much leisure activity is also at risk of losing its purpose.

Location: 2,730

It might even come to appear as though there would be no point in us doing anything—not working long hours for money, of course; but there would also be no point in putting effort into raising children, no point in going out shopping, no point in studying, no point in going to the gym or practicing the piano... et cetera.

Location: 2,736

We are left to deal with the discovery that the place of maximal freedom is actually a void.

Location: 2,802

Traditional wisdom therefore recommends taking a more oblique approach in our pursuit of happiness.¹⁰⁸ “Happiness—a butterfly, which, when pursued, seems always just beyond your grasp; but if you sit down quietly, may alight upon you.”¹⁰⁹ This wisdom would lead us astray, however, if we applied it to a scenario in which its underlying premiss—that chasing after pleasure is self-defeating—does not obtain: such as one that plays out in a setting where the technology exists whereby one really can induce pleasure by directly aiming at it, and where one can do so reliably and lastingly. Somebody might have the intuition that “a world in which mind engineering is used to induce pleasure would feel stale and unsatisfying after a while”. But this intuition is simply false.

Location: 3,557

I want to point out that there is another important consequence of technological maturity, besides the obviation of human effort. A technologically mature world is plastic. I mean this in the sense that it has affordances that make it easy to achieve any preferred local configuration.

Location: 3,567

An important special case of plasticity is that you have the ability to modify yourself in whichever way you want. In one of my early works, I termed this ability autopotency.¹²³ An autopotent being is one that has complete power over itself, including its internal states. It has the requisite technology, and the know-how to use it, to reconfigure itself as it sees fit, both physically and mentally.

Location: 3,679

For each category of utopia, there is a correlate category of dystopia. One that focuses on the same type of problematic but characterizes it by painting in negatives, showing us what failure would look like. Usually not as a prediction about the future but as a critique of some pernicious pattern in the author’s contemporary society. In classical governance & culture dystopias, for example, the problematic pattern might be oppressive totalitarianism (Nineteen Eighty-Four) or dehumanizing consumerism (Brave New World). In a post-scarcity dystopia, it could be alienation or social disconnectedness. In a post-work dystopia, the issue might be tedium and indolence. In post-instrumental or plastic dystopias, the problematic would be a sense of meaninglessness or of the world becoming uninterestingly arbitrary and untethered.

Note | Location: 3,685Location: 3,736

Arthur Schopenhauer, the great nineteenth-century German pessimist who took inspiration from the Vedic tradition, the Upanishads in particular—a core part of his philosophy centers on a basic predicament: the dilemma we face between the pain that comes from unsatisfied desires and the boredom we experience in the absence of unsatisfied desires: “The most general survey shows us that the two foes of human happiness are pain and boredom. We may go further, and say that in the degree in which we are fortunate enough to get away from the one, we approach the other. . . . Accordingly, while the lower classes are engaged in a ceaseless struggle with need, in other words, with pain, the upper carry on a constant and often desperate battle with boredom.”¹³⁰ Thus life, according to Schopenhauer, “swings like a pendulum to and fro between pain and boredom”.

Location: 3,776

So at technological maturity we will have the means to engineer away our ability to experience boredom, yet one might worry that doing so would have undesirable consequences because of the usefulness of boredom as a prod to push us away from boringness. If we think that being in objectively boring conditions is bad, this lends a certain instrumental value to our capacity for feeling subjective boredom.

Location: 3,783

On a larger scale, there is ennui or existential boredom. This mood indicates that we are wasting our life. It makes us almost viscerally experience the void of meaning that can occur if we fail to devote ourselves to somebody or something of sufficient importance to us, or if we come to suspect that we are pursuing a dead end. In a favorable case, the ennui causes us to rethink our priorities, and to abandon a sterile life path and begin a quest for a truer calling.

Location: 4,040

Thus the contemplation of beauty, whether refracted through art and poetry or focused directly on our surroundings, is one proposal for how utopians might fill the hours of an endless summer. By the way, Schopenhauer, too, saw disinterested aesthetic contemplation as one of only two possible ways to escape the reciprocating motion of want and boredom that powers our suffering (the other way being the path of the saint, which he conceived of as involving the self-abnegation of the will). Importantly, the objects that Mill and Schopenhauer had in mind as the focus of aesthetic contemplation were not necessarily or even preferably those of world-changing transformations, dramatic turnarounds, high stakes, or groundbreaking discoveries—not “interestingness” in a sense that depends on learning profound truths or solving pressing problems. Rather, they had in mind a beauty that is available equally in the small and mundane, in how the water flows in a brook, or the particular way that an oak tree spreads its branches, or that a workman’s shoulders move when he is digging a ditch.

Location: 4,659

And although the years may bring some modicum of understanding of the workings of the world, it tends to come late, often too late—making it seem like the only fruit that grows on the tree of experience is resignation. Wisdom withered on the bough.

Location: 5,498

Out here on the open ocean of full redundancy, with no landmarks in sight—no practical necessities by which to steer—our only recourse, if we are to maintain our bearings over the *longue durée*, is celestial navigation. The higher or more ethereal values to which I have referred, such as interestingness, fulfillment, richness, purpose, and meaning: these are like guiding stars and constellations. The light we receive from them may be relatively faint (compared to that from the smiling sun of hedonic gratification), but it is important for maintaining our long-range normative course of travel.

Location: 5,553

“[T]he most fulfilling [life paths] are those that best fit one’s latent talents, interests, and initial bent and with one’s evolving self-ideal (as opposed to one’s conscious desires or formulated ambitions).”¹⁸⁰ “[Human lives] approach fulfillment insofar as they fill their natural allotment of years with vigorous activity. They need not be ‘successful’, or ‘triumphant’, or even contented on balance in order to be fulfilled, provided they are long lifetimes full of struggles and strivings, achievements and noble failures, contentments and frustrations, friendships and enmities, exertions and relaxations, seriousness and playfulness through all the programmed stages of growth and decay. Most important of all, a fulfilled human life will be a life of planning, designing, making order out of confusion and system out of randomness, a life of building, repairing, rebuilding, creating, pursuing goals, and solving problems.”¹⁸¹

Location: 5,679

I’ll introduce the concept of richness by quoting from a recent article in *Psychological Review* by Shigehiro Oishi and Erin Westgate. They write: “[W]e argue that a psychologically rich life consists of interesting experiences in which novelty and/or complexity are accompanied by profound changes in perspective. . . . Thus, on their deathbed, a person who has led a happy life might say, ‘I had fun!’ A person who has led a meaningful life might say, ‘I made a difference!’ And a person who has led a psychologically rich life might say, ‘What a journey!’”¹⁸⁴ The authors find that a significant minority of people across several countries report they would prefer a life that is psychologically rich to one that is happy or meaningful.

Location: 5,753

Actually, I expect that virtual worlds will be experienced as decidedly more real than the physical world—more vivid, engaging, fruitful, relevant, and psychologically impactful. Many of us already spend more of our time and attention in the worlds of thought and imagination than we do focusing on the objects before us in our physical surroundings—and we find these mental conjurings quite sufficiently “real”, much of the time, even within the limitations of our current primitive cognitive and technological methods of *mise-en-scène*. (And I’m not even referring to the simulation hypothesis here.)

Location: 6,014

Schemas for esteem-allocation are a core feature of culture. Cultures leverage our esteem-craving to incentivize us to pursue a wide range of projects, including projects that would otherwise seem arbitrary and pointless. The pursuit of such culturally sponsored projects is a source of deep and fulfilling purpose in many people's lives.

Location: 6,017

If we take our golf example: think of how ridiculous it must appear—if we adopt a detached perspective and consider this activity outside the context of a culture that values people who develop skill in this particular endeavor—in fact, how disturbingly close to insanity it must appear, to devote the prime decades of one's life to the project of improving one's skill at hitting a small ball with a club into a series of narrow holes.

Location: 7,238

The basic idea of (FT3) is that a person's life is more meaningful to the extent that she employs her reason to engage appropriately with the fundamental conditions of human existence—which, according to Metz, consists in the pursuit of “the good, the true, and the beautiful”. He gives us some examples of highly meaningful lives. Nelson Mandela: helping to end a fundamental injustice (“the good”). Albert Einstein: discovering fundamental facts about the universe (“the true”). Fyodor Dostoevsky: expressing fundamental themes of the human condition (“the beautiful”).

Location: 7,257

This narrative dimension also entails that meaning is greater if a life is original. A life that is a cookie-cutter replica of some other life, or a life that is too conventional and similar to millions of other lives, is, other things equal, less meaningful than the life of somebody who is a one-of-a-kind and who does things their way.

Location: 7,260

To these elements, Metz adds a further complication. Meaning is reduced, he claims, if reason is negatively oriented toward what is fundamentally important. Here we can consider the life of Adolf Hitler.

Location: 7,274

The question of meaning in life is anyway not intended to be a question of that life's all-things-considered desirability. This is something that Metz himself is at pains to emphasize. He states that it is possible for one life to have more meaning than another, yet be worse overall: for instance, if the more meaningful life contains a greater burden of pain. So if hedonic welfare is an additional dimension, beside meaningfulness, along which we evaluate the overall desirability of life, then why not regard moral righteousness as yet another dimension? And, we might add, why not several other dimensions too—such as interestingness, fulfillment, richness, and purposefulness, among others? If we take such a pluralistic approach, we would feel less need to cram so many considerations into the concept of meaningfulness as we are forced to do if we insist on relying on meaningfulness as the sole criterion of how prudentially desirable a life is (or as the only criterion besides hedonic well-being).

Location: 7,346

if understanding fundamental truths or aesthetically appreciating fundamental beauty is what lights and fans the fires of meaning, then nothing prevents the lives of utopians from blazing white-hot. If, on the other hand, meaning comes only from making original contributions to the world's stock of fundamental knowledge or its collection of beautiful artifacts, then their situation may be less conducive to meaning. Our analysis here would parallel yesterday's discussion of purpose. The problem is twofold. First, utopia would soon contain an overabundance of knowledge and beauty. This would make it harder to effect a significant increase—certainly in percentage terms, but perhaps also in absolute terms. This is especially true for certain kinds of timeless science.

Location: 7,375

The problem of originality came up in our investigation of interestingness in yesterday's lecture. The upshot, in a nutshell, was that the most we can hope for in utopia is mere local uniqueness. But this is also true in our current condition; and yet we seem little troubled by that fact.

Location: 7,446

Originality is challenging if there are many other lives, and repetition is challenging if your life goes on for a long time.

Location: 7,512

It is true that good books and films have been inspired by wars and atrocities. It would have been better if these wars and atrocities had not occurred and we had not had these books and films. The same applies at the personal scale. People coping with the loss of a child, dementia, abject poverty, cancer, depression, severe abuse: I submit it would be worth giving up a lot of good stories to get rid of those harms. If that makes our lives less meaningful, so be it. Remember that our task is not to create a future that is good for telling stories about, but one that is good to live in.

Location: 7,567

It is possible that a meaning crisis is more likely to afflict those who are in other respects quite well off: those who have resources, human or material, that are at risk of being wasted unless deployed for some worthwhile use. If that is correct, then it is not those whose daily lives are a struggle for existence who are most at risk of suffering from a lack of meaning—for in a sense they have their hands full with just surviving—but rather those who have some amount of slack in their lives, who have comparatively much to forfeit and to lose.

Location: 7,590

What is required for meaning, I think, is that the thing to which one devotes oneself to—be it a goal or a role, or even an ideal—is such that (a) one believes, and wholeheartedly feels, that it is something really worth devoting oneself to, and (b) devoting oneself to it is sufficiently demanding to fill up one's life, or a good chunk of it at least—one's time, talents, energy, and ability to endure.

Location: 7,606

In our personal relationships, too, we crave irreplaceability. It is often more attainable there than it is in our professional lives. Irrespective of your capabilities, of whether you are sick or healthy, young or old: if you are somebody's mother or father, or somebody's child, you are, in a very real sense, irreplaceable. Likewise if you are somebody's true love: you then are irreplaceable to at least one person. That answers to a deep need.

Location: 7,721

we can measure the worth of very many goods and services in dollars; and recently we've also begun to develop precise indices of our social standing, accounted in units of subscribers, thumbs up, views, followers, and friends. Overall: more numbers, less myth and less meaning.

Location: 7,723

It is true that our close interpersonal relations are still mostly run by our intuitive and affective faculties, rather than by science-based models or analytic reasoning. It is still possible for people to talk about "the miracle of love"—barely. So romance is one place we could look for remnants of meaning-as-enchantment in our contemporary lives. But of course, our inventors and entrepreneurs are hard at work technologizing this remaining nature preserve too, for example by moving courtship to dating sites with quantifiable metrics and standardized interfaces. My colleagues in the brain sciences and in evolutionary psychology are also doing their best to demystify human mating and pair bonding. But there is still a difference between theoretical understanding and practical ability.

Location: 7,753

Some things we enjoy doing. Other things we enjoy having done. Meaningful activities tend to fall into the latter category. Meaning sustains motivation even during periods when immediate reward is not forthcoming.

Note | Location: 7,755Location: 7,773

People who become great do so, in part, because they found meaning. Their project becomes something more than a goal: it becomes part of their identity. Their whole soul buys into the endeavor. This enables the great person to go further than anyone who is driven only by calculating rationality and a will-powered pursuit of instrumental precepts.

Location: 7,778

For human-like creatures, it is paramount to understand and align with one's social context and life situation. Our cognitive, emotional, and volitional capacities are molded to facilitate such conformity. One possible root of meaning might lie in the importance of collective agency. The individual must discern and adjust to the implicit intentionality of the group's collective endeavors and inclinations.

Location: 7,783

Another possible root is that we might have developed meaning-supporting psychological faculties to enable adherence to our own individual long-term projects, and not only to the tribe's intentionality.

Location: 7,792

Meaning-based motivation has a degree of independence of the immediate circumstances in which we find ourselves. This is because it does not derive from expectations of imminent reward, nor from fluctuating drives and appetites. It derives instead from convictions anchored in a larger external pattern of priorities.

Location: 7,819

Meaning as Encompassing Transcendental Purpose A purpose P is the meaning of person S's life if and only if: (i) P is encompassing for S; (ii) S has strong reason to embrace P; and (iii) the reason is derived from a context of justification that is external to S's mundane existence. Furthermore, we can say that P is the meaning of life (simpliciter) if P is the meaning of life for nearly everybody. (And P is the meaning of human life if P is the meaning of life for nearly every human individual.)

Location: 7,828

By "purpose" I mean something that could serve as an aspirational focus, something that one might strive toward. It need not be a "goal" in the narrow sense of something that would lead one to attempt to attain some particular outcome or end state. Goal-focused purposes are possible, but meaning might also be found in purposes that are role-focused (involving an aspiration to play a certain role with integrity and excellence) or ideal-focused (involving an aspiration to live faithfully in accordance with some ideal). In the case of role-focused or ideal-focused purposes, there may be no definite outcome that one is aiming toward—rather, one would be striving to conduct oneself in a certain manner, in accordance with the demands of the role or the principles or templates associated with the ideal.

Location: 7,848

For a purpose to be a potential meaning of life, it should be able to fill a life or at least a substantial portion of a life.

Location: 7,855

Other things equal, the stronger the reason a person has for embracing the purpose in question, the more it can qualify as being the meaning of their life. For a maximum of meaning, the reason should be so strong that it clearly overrides any other reasons the person has for being concerned with things unrelated to the purpose.

Location: 7,865

The idea is that meaning is a special kind of purpose that is derived not from some particular thing in our life that we happen to need or fancy, but instead from reasons anchored in some larger pattern of value or concern—some pattern that transcends our own normal mundane existence and whatever desirabilities may therein be present. Although, in a literal sense, the rewards of an afterlife would be occurring within the person's own life, yet they are sufficiently outside the person's mundane existence (with its day-to-day preoccupations and concerns) to count as external to it, and thus to offer a potential separate basis for the derivation of worthwhileness of some encompassing undertaking.

Location: 7,890

Because a meaningful purpose is derived from outside of our own ordinary immediate selfish preoccupations, it can provide a source of motivation that is independent of our usual myopic and egocentric perspective. Meaning can thus give a person a kind of qualified immunity

from the vicissitudes of ordinary life.

Location: 7,898

Or as Nietzsche put it, “Hat man sein warum? des Lebens, so verträgt man sich fast mit jedem wie?”

Location: 7,918

When, however, we move to a secular setting, especially one that is sufficiently prosperous to offer some respite from the exigencies of mere survival, and that is sufficiently liberal and multicultural to offer a swirl of alternative ideologies, lifestyles, moralities, professions, et cetera—any one of which could potentially form the basis for a socially viable existence—then the problem of meaning becomes acute. It is no longer obvious what, if anything, constitutes a mission that one could wholeheartedly embrace. One problem is that there could be too many potential missions, presenting a difficulty of choosing. Another problem is that it may be unclear that any of the potential missions is actually worthwhile: worth dedicating a life to, worth toiling for decades to serve, honor, achieve—given the availability of rather convenient alternatives, such as just floating along in a state of comfort and grabbing some fun here and there as opportunities present themselves.

Location: 7,929

It is not only cultural developments that can precipitate a meaning crisis; developments within an individual life trajectory can also do so. Consider, for example, somebody who charges hard for success, optimizing their conduct for the attainment of the material or social highlife.

Location: 7,936

In the midlife crisis our protagonist becomes aware of the lack of meaning in their life. The meaninglessness was previously papered over by non-meaningful striving. Now that the glue of ambition is weakening, and the future success-hopes are peeling off, the depressing underlying reality of their life and career, which they have worked so hard to construct, is revealed—as the cement walls of a prison cell.

Location: 7,979

As has been pointed out—most famously by Albert Camus, another thinker in the existentialist tradition—Sisyphus’s predicament in important respects mirrors our own.²¹⁰ Our labors, too, might seem repetitive, pointless, and ultimately futile. We spend a lifetime acquiring knowledge, skills, character, money, fame, and friends... and then we die: “Everyone’s life thus resembles one of Sisyphus’s climbs to the summit of his hill, and each day of it one of his steps; the difference is that whereas Sisyphus himself returns to push the stone up again, we leave this to our children.”²¹¹ The ultimate futility of our endeavors seems total. We die. Eventually everyone who knew us dies. Then our civilization dies. Finally, even the universe itself seems fated to expire in the coils of the second law of thermodynamics (that implacable nomological boa!). Everything thus comes to naught in the end.

Location: 8,093

will say that Sisyphus has subjective meaning if he is in fact wholeheartedly embracing a purpose that is encompassing and that he takes himself to have strong reason to pursue on grounds that are external to his mundane existence. Sisyphus has objective meaning if there is some purpose that would be encompassing to him and that he has a strong reason to embrace—a reason that derives from a context of justification that is external to his own mundane existence.

Location: 8,284

The most plausible candidates for a strongly shared meaning among many (or all) humans, therefore, probably require a more objective notion of meaning—such as one that imputes that the reason we all have for embracing the purpose in question is that it is derivable from an independent moral reality.

Location: 8,305

SOME CATEGORIES OF POSSIBLE MEANINGS Reward Religious afterlife Posthumanity
Simulation possibilities Nirvana Morality Consequentialism Deontology Virtue Worship Zeal
Cause Identity Allegiance Dedication